

"WE CANNOT AFFORD B

In between accepting condolences from hordes of mourners at the Bhuttos' ancestral house in Naudero, Larkana, PPP Co-chairman Asif Zardari spoke exclusively to Managing Editor RAJ CHENGAPPA and contributor HASAN ZAIDI on a range of issues. Excerpts:

Q. Why didn't you take over the mantle of PPP instead of making your son Bilawal the chairperson and someone else the party's prime ministerial candidate?

A. The party in its wisdom did it, after I proposed it to the Central Executive Committee—the largest body of PPP—that for continuity it was needed. The people of Pakistan are hopelessly disgruntled; they are dejected and hurt. The youth of Pakistan, which is in the majority in the country today, needs a new beacon. When nations have hope, nations survive.

Q. If PPP wins the elections and there is pressure on you to take over as prime minister, would you accept it or play the role Sonia Gandhi does in India?

A. I can never imagine to be as great as Soniji. She's a great leader. I'm too small and too humble and too new at it. She's earned her spurs; she had brought back the largest political party in power after a long period of opposition. I'm looking forward to creating the institution of PPP. Governments come and go, but parties survive.

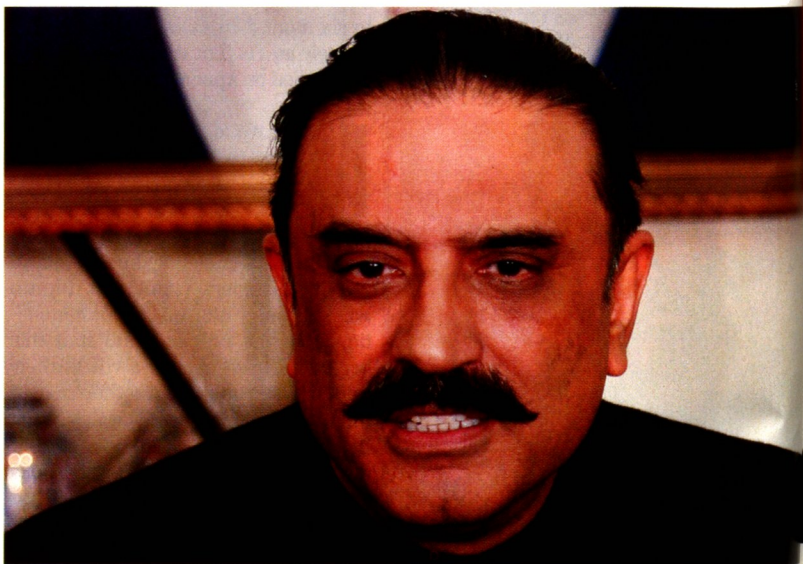
Q. But with Bilawal being appointed the party chief, has it not perpetuated a certain kind of dynastic politics, rather than true democratic values that PPP espouses?

A. First of all, in her wisdom, she left a political will to guide us. She left the will dated October 16, two days before she left Dubai for Pakistan. She was warned of the threats and the danger to her life, and maybe she could foresee what was going to happen to her. She could think ahead and gave a suggestion; after all, the political will was not binding. The party and its high command, which is nearly 120 people, could have chosen otherwise. She in

her judgement thought it fit to ask me to step in her place and then I could select. And we all collectively thought that Bilawal should be given the charge as a hope for tomorrow.

Q. It takes a lot for a father to hand over such a mantle to his son.

A. Let's say, I was duty-bound by her legacy because if she hadn't left the will, we would have had some other decision. I would have gone away in my grief for at least a year or two. I would have just taken care of the charitable institutions that she had left behind.



AP PHOTO/B K BANGASH

But by binding me to her legacy, she has left the path for the future.

Q. You have not answered the question that if the party overwhelmingly says you must be the prime minister, would you then accept it?

A. Like I said earlier, she knew that I was not contesting the polls. I am aware of the fact that it can be changed. There's a seat lying vacant. I can contest from her seat. But at the moment, we need to get ourselves together, get the people together, get the party together and do a lot of fire-fighting rather than get into who's going to be the prime minister and who's going to be the office-bearer. I think we need to

save Pakistan. We hope to convert this martyrdom, this loss and sorrow into an energy to take Pakistan forward towards democracy rather than crumple and breakaway.

Q. When you were a minister you were jailed for charges that included corruption and extortion. You were even called Mr 10 Per Cent.

A. We are a country where the chief justice can be charged with corruption. We can be put back in power and then be re-arrested. It is the oldest trick in the book for the establishment. Now

the Government is already on record with a Cabinet decision admitting that these cases were politically motivated.

Q. What did being 11 years in jail teach you?

A. It has taught me to live with myself, to look into myself and make my inner self as big as the problem, whatever it is, and to confront it. Because man's inner strength is as large as the universe is.

Q. Before marriage, your image was that of a polo-playing playboy.

A. These are the ways of my detractors who have been looking to come to power and trying to weaken democracy. I did play polo. But we are an Islamic